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Joe Williams

Joe Williams was born Joseph Goreed in 1918 in Cordele, Georgia. At the age of three, his family relocated to Chicago, where he spent his formative years. He has been a professional jazz singer since 1937 and had worked with Coleman Hawkins, Lionel Hampton, Andy Kirk and Red Saunders before joining the Count Basie band in 1954. His contribution to that ensemble "elevated the entire band to a new plateau of commercial success," according to jazz critic Leonard Feather. Since becoming a solo singer in 1961, he has been equally successful at a time when rock threatened to swamp the world of jazz music. His recording output has never dwindled through the 60s, 70s, and 80s, and in the 90s he continues to be one of America's great interpreters of jazz standards and blues.

Joe was interviewed by his biographer, Leslie Gourse, on March 9, 1996 in New York City. Monk Rowe also participated briefly in the interview.

LG: We are filming for the Hamilton College Archives. This is Joe Williams and I'm Leslie Gourse. I need the introduction, Joe does not.

JW: That's nice.

LG: And I wanted to ask you, Joe, you know you've had such a wonderful, successful career. And I once did ask you, how did you know to make the right decisions for yourself? What guided you? And you answered me, you said, "Oh, every day, every day." Now I really don't know if you meant the song gave you such a wonderful boost, I mean the great hit that you had with Basie, or did you just mean that you learned every day as you went along to take risks and to stick your neck out, and to enjoy the fruits of your successes.

JW: I never have thought I was sticking my neck out.

LG: No?

JW: No, no. You do what you do. I sing. And if I feel like I want to sing something I do it. I used to have some problems with Mr. Basie sometimes. I would ask, I'd say, "Hey, Bas', I'd like to get an arrangement on" such and such a song. And he'd say, "Oh, you don't need that thing. Sing the things you've been singing." You know. If you let people, even those closest to you — and he was very close to me — if you let them discourage you from doing what you feel you want to do, in many instances it'll leave you one dimensional as opposed to being a person of some variety. So consequently you have to fight even those that you love and those that are closest to you. Because I remember after bugging him for a long time to do something, when we finally did it, and the audience approval was so enthusiastic, he would look at me and he would nod his head. And you

say hey, you don't need that. There's no need for you do to that. You know like if you believe in it strongly, do it. And that's what happened all the way along the line. I wanted to do a spiritual album since 1957. But the fellas didn't want me to. People were enjoying some remuneration from my success as a quote unquote sox symbol — a sex symbol. A sox symbol you know. Yeah. As in a boxer, you know. They felt that if I were to do a spiritual album that it would take away from my aura as a sex symbol or something like that.

LG: Oh, no.

JW: Yeah. They felt that it would.

LG: Well Gospel can be sexy. Mahalia Jackson proved that.

JW: Gospel is spiritual.

LG: But it can be — oh well.

JW: There. And that is the secret. I mean because with sex —

LG: I mean really not sexy, but exciting.

JW: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Gospel is spiritual. And there's very little more exciting than someone who is spiritual as well. I was talking to my wife whom you know is British, about Camilla Parker Bowles. She must entertain his head, you know, Charles. She keeps him laughing and happy and loose and feeling like a human being. That's what it's about. And I've known people like that.

LG: Not carried away by publicity perhaps. Able to keep that level head.

JW: Yeah. I've known people that just were amusing. And they know how to push your buttons. And they keep you laughing uproariously all the time. And that's a gift in itself, to be able to make people laugh. I remember one woman saying to me once she says, "They must be kidding, talking about making marijuana legal." She said, "If they did nothing would get done." Wonderful. And she also said something very spiritual I think. When Mr. Basie died she says, "What are we going to do? Because Basie used to come to town and open the windows of our spirit." But she was an English teacher so, you know. One of those people who came from that DuBois background in Washington, D.C. Rosemary Clifford Wilson. A graduate of Howard University and then went on to teach high school. But if you listen people say funny things, you know, like oh, keep you laughing. My wife said to me the other day, "Is she your Camilla Parker Bowles?" I said, "No, no, no, no." It's like Lester Young talking about Billie Holiday, he said, "We love each other but we don't nasty." Isn't that elegant? You know like and just spell it right out.

LG: He had his own language.

JW: Yeah, didn't he?

JW: It should be.

LG: So you made this Gospel album, did you not?

JW: Yes we did. A spiritual. You haven't heard it yet?

LG: No.

JW: "Feel the Spirit."

LG: Oh, can I just take a look at the songs in it?

JW: Yeah.

LG: Oh, "His Eye is on the Sparrow," isn't that nice. I love that. I love that. Do you know the song "Moving On Up?" Have you ever heard that one?

JW: "Moving On Up?" Which one?

LG: Moving on up to the higher room.

JW: Oh, yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah, I've heard it. I've heard it. I don't know it. A spiritual.

LG: It's a very old one, isn't it?

JW: Yeah. Yeah. "Moving on Up."

LG: Oh, I've got to hear this. I didn't hear it. This is on, oh it's got to be great, Telarc, yes. Okay. Now I have something to do this afternoon after this. I was reading through your discography of all the recordings that you've made. You've worked with everyone who is — well not everyone — but you've worked with so many people.

JW: Yes, yes.

LG: Harry "Sweets" Edison, and I like that Bohanon, the trombonist you worked with, and so many of them. I mean I love them. Jimmy Jones and everyone.

JW: Yup, yup, yup, yup, yup. Hank Jones, Jimmy Jones, Osie Johnson, Milt Hinton, Kenny Burrell, oh boy, Romeo Penque, Harold Lookofsky. Really all these wonderful — Zoot Sims, Frank Foster, and —

LG: And the Jones-Lewis band. The Thad Jones-Mel Lewis band.

JW: Oh, yeah, Thad Jones and Mel Lewis Orchestra. Yeah Mel, yeah I did several.

LG: And Cannonball.

JW: And Cannonball. Julian "Cannonball" Adderley. Yes. Happy, happy.

LG: Yes that was a great recording. People just praised it to the skies. Do you have favorites?

JW: Me?

LG: Yeah. Among the recordings that you've made?

JW: Normally it's the next one I'm going to do. You know, the one you're working on. The one you're planning in your subconscious even. And planning whether you want to do a theme. I've never done a theme CD, or a theme album. And that seems to be very, very popular. But I would decide, if I do a theme thing, I think it should be Ellington.

LG: Sure, why not? Maybe you should do one Ellington and one Gershwin. That would be

JW: Yeah Gershwin. Oh, Gershwin's so great, yeah. I'd love to give Gershwin the treatment, yeah.

LG: I think that would be nice.

JW: Yeah. Gershwin has so many things that you can do. Sarah [Vaughan] did a Gershwin thing.

LG: Oh wasn't that spectacular?

JW: Super. Absolutely super, yeah.

LG: She loved that. She told someone that she thought it was one of her favorites, maybe her favorite album. She felt that you could just listen to it and it would have the same effect as if you were seeing her live.

JW: Right. That is quite true.

LG: And that's an important thing.

JW: Yeah. She had a chance to shine. That music is so popular.

LG: The music is popular, yeah.

JW: All over the world.

LG: It is good.

JW: Have you heard the thing Sarah did though of the Pope's writings?

LG: Yes.

JW: That —

LG: You like that?

JW: Oh, gosh.

LG: I like the end piece on it. It was nice. I remember that.

JW: I think the whole thing was special. Very, very special you know. The mystery of man. And when it says "I turn little screws — all I do is I just turn little screws, making weapons that would destroy us all. And I have no say in the way of the world. I just turn little screws and make weapons." That's part of the CD. Oh, the essence. It's like reading *Dr. Zhivago*, the book, and missing the essence of the book. The essence of that book was never in the motion picture. They made a romance out of the thing there. But the essence in that book was this woman who thought she was dying of tuberculosis. She wanted Dr. Zhivago's opinion. He told her, he says, "You're not going to die first of all. Your crisis is passed, your fever's broke and you're healing now you know, your body's healing, your lungs are healing." And she says, "But talk to me anyway. Tell me about death and life and what—" And he told her he says, "Well your consciousness is like a light on a train going down the track so that you can see where you're going. It's only when you turn the light inward that you're headed for a wreck."

LG: Wow.

LG: I did. I read it thoroughly, but you know, I read it in college I think. That's quite a while ago. And I remember loving it, loving it. But when, now you must turn the light inward sometimes. You know?

JW: You think so?

LG: Well I mean self knowledge, to know who you are.

JW: All right, okay, but for expression, I mean, your aura and your attitudes are what you're really living by. And which ones make you happy, which makes you a more rounded person.

LG: Yes, I guess we live by instinct to a great degree, but also I think we live by discipline, by telling ourselves what to do.

JW: Oh, yes, by all means.

LG: Yeah, I think so.

JW: And what not to do as well. Like I say I go see everybody, all the performers, because I want to know what not to do as well.

LG: You know I remember that you too had some trouble with your lungs when you were a youngster, you had TB.

JW: Yes.

LG: So this would have special meaning for you. And you were 16 or so?

JW: Yes. 14, 15 — 15. Supposedly I had a spot on my left lung. And they gave me pneumothorax where they collapsed the lung so it would rest. They stuck a needle between the ribs you know, regularly, for almost a year, before it settled, and told me I wasn't supposed to raise my arms above my head, so basketball was out you know, and sports and all that. And I played soccer in grammar school, handball, tennis and football, touch football and baseball and all that mess.

LG: Yeah you were a great athlete.

JW: But there I was running all the time.

LG: Did you have any idea you would become a great singer? Did you have any idea you would be able to sing, because it's such a — your lungs—

JW: I always could sing.

LG: But I mean for a career because of that.

JW: I never thought of it as a career.

LG: Oh, it was just something you did.

JW: No that happened quite by accident. People started offering me money to sing and they kept offering me more money and more money, and it paid the rent and I was able to save some. Stuff like that. That just happened. Because I was singing with orchestras for dancing.

JW: Yup.

LG: Jimmie Noone?

JW: Erskine Tate.

LG: Right.

JW: Yup, yup.

LG: King Kolax. Was that a dance band?

JW: Yeah. Kolax had a dance band before he had a nightclub. Red Saunders.

LG: Red Saunders and the DeLisa. Did you learn a great deal —

JW: Andy Kirk. We were playing for dancing even then. And Lionel Hampton too.

LG: Right. You toured with Lionel Hampton.

JW: We were doing a lot of theaters and some colleges too. That became very prevalent. What started that? I think George Shearing started that a lot. Shearing and Stan Kenton —

LG: Going to colleges?

JW: Yeah. Playing. And it's such a brilliant idea because you're really building your audience for the future, whether you know it or not, because these students will grow up and become the wage earners who can afford to come and see you at the different venues that you're working when you go out. So it's marvelous.

LG: And they're major buyers of records anyway, even on campus.

JW: Yes.

LG: I think so. I remember.

JW: Oh, yes. They'd have record hops. Remember them? When you were in school?

LG: Well no I was in Columbia, I used to listen to Symphony Sid and go hear you at Birdland.

JW: Oh my gosh.

LG: So there was a difference, a different sophistication.

JW: Yeah.

LG: But I did buy records in those days.

JW: My first records were "Koko" by Ellington, "Koko," "Truckin'" —

LG: Koko the blues singer?

JW: No, no, no, no. Ellington wrote a thing called "Koko," which somebody later stole and used it. They always used things of his though. Like "Night Train" is the fourth tenor part of "Happy Go Lucky" of Ellington's. But who was it that did [scats] Great line. Then Joe Nanton came in [scats].

LG: Oh you're marvelous. You're a whole band.

JW: But those are things I grew up with. I bought those records before I had anything to play on. I couldn't — I didn't have a machine. Later on I got a machine to play them on. But I loved the music.

LG: They have the most fantastic use of the mutes, the most creative. Up until that time and never since has it been surpassed.

JW: I used to cover the "Sophisticated Jungle." Really sophisticated.

LG: Well they called it jungle music.

JW: Oh sure they did. Well they had a name for it all. They had race records. You'd race to the store and get 'em. Thirty cents. Thirty-five cents. Boy.

LG: When did you — when you had the chance to make that record with the recordings with Basie that made you such a well known singer, did you know, did you have any idea that it would become —

JW: No.

LG: You just knew you were going to like doing it, I'll bet.

JW: We were doing it before. We were doing it before we recorded it.

LG: Sure.

JW: I joined the band the day after Christmas in New York here, and we went on a southern tour. And Frank Foster and Ernie Wilkins, we got together in Jacksonville, Florida at a place called the Two Spot I think it was then. And we were down there about three or four days in one place. And they made the arrangements on "Every Day I Have the Blues," "The Comeback," "Teach Me Tonight." And we came to Washington, D.C., rehearsed that morning in the Howard Theater and performed that evening, that afternoon and that evening for the week, and then we came into New York, stopped at Hagerstown, Maryland and played a dance there, and then came in to New York City and opened at Birdland. And from the opening night, "Every Day I Have the Blues" was a big, big, big success. And then we went on tour with the Birdland stars of 1955, which was the Basie band, Sarah Vaughan, Lester Young, Stan Getz, Erroll Garner, Bud Powell — who else? Anyway Birdland stars of 1955. People didn't work Birdland then. And Zoot Sims I think was part of that group. And we went on tour and we were performing "Every Day I Have the Blues," with the orchestra, before thousands of people all over the country. In February we went in the studio and recorded it for Norman Granz and that and "The Comeback" and "Every Day I've Fallen in Love All Over Again With You" that Foster did for me, "In the Evening." That stuff that was in the first LP that we did. "Count Basie Swings and Joe Williams Sings." And—

LG: "Alright O.K. You Win" that was on there?

JW: Yeah, we put that in, I think that's on the LP as well. And anyway, it turned out that all the stuff, everything was well received. And "My Baby Upsets Me," which I wrote, and it all turned out well, everything you know. "Roll 'Em Pete," of course "Teach Me Tonight," "My Baby Upsets Me," "Please Send Me Someone to Love" which was

LG: Did you choose these songs or did you and Basie confer?

JW: The only one that was chosen by Basie was "Alright O.K. You Win."

LG: Yeah. He told you to do that. You didn't want to?

JW: Yeah I didn't want to, but we did.

LG: I get such a kick out of hearing — oh I love to hear you sing to me. When I sit here and you sing to me, or anytime across the table, it's great. But you once sang something about fifty chicks under twenty —

JW: "Smack Dab in the Middle." Yeah.

LG: And I wonder if you'd sing that — just that line in a couple of those languages.

JW: Oh you mean yeah, in German, yeah, sure. [speaks German words].

LG: You remember it?

JW: Yeah. You don't forget the languages. I've traveled over there so much.

LG: Yeah. It's a real education.

JW: Yeah.

LG: Who guided you? So you chose mainly but Basie chose that song. Who guided you to make certain decisions? Was it just — was it your mother that gave you vision from the early childhood? She brought home magazines and things for you to read?

JW: Yeah.

LG: She must have given you vision that you would have, you know—

JW: A very, very broad spectrum was at my disposal, where anything that you imagined — and I read a lot, I love to read, you know. When I was a kid particularly I read everything I could get my hands on. I used to read the editorials on maybe three or four newspapers a day. You know, different views of things, what have you.

LG: And I know you like music because your mother played, she was a musician.

JW: She played piano. And my aunt as well.

LG: Right.

JW: And we sang in the home all the time.

LG: Right. Oh you did, you did sing in the home a lot together.

JW: Yeah.

LG: Aha. And she took you to certain — in the park.

JW: Oh yeah.

LG: The concerts in the park?

JW: The Grant Park in Chicago. They used to have symphony concerts in the summer and free. And you'd sit there at the band shell and listen to the Chicago Symphony. And you'd hear the popular singers, the classical singers of the day. Lilly Pons, Tibbitt I think his name was.

JW: Lawrence Tibbet. And John Charles Thomas.

LG: I remember him.

JW: Yeah.

LG: My father loved him.

JW: Yeah. And Rosa Ponselle, who used to do "Carmen" I remember. And of course on the radio we had the Metropolitan every Saturday.

LG: Right.

JW: And they trapped me on Saturday. Instead of playing in the street, they'd say, "Darling, the windows need washing," and we had a seven room house — I mean apartment — there in Chicago. So there I was washing the windows and suddenly on the radio, Milton J. Cross and the Metropolitan Opera. So I was given another vision other than the street and the houses of pleasure, and other things that I might have gotten into. And church every Sunday. Every Sunday was church. Sometimes I'd go to rehearsal with my mother. Choir rehearsal was on Thursday.

LG: So there was always the encouragement there to the cultural-inclined, with music and —

JW: My group had a lot of class. A lot of class. Elegant. It was dignity, great dignity. I always remember my grandmother you know. Oh, you'd think she was Queen Mary. You know like she was the dowager queen. You know, she was like [gestures], oh, and quiet. I never heard her raise her voice. Never. It was something. But they were so cute, I think if I'd done something in the street to embarrass our family they would have killed me, or at least make me wish I was dead or something.

LG: And then as —

JW: And you always deal with the spirit of those that loved you. Like part Indian and part African. Okay. O Great Spirit, yes, the Great Spirit that you know is part of all of us. Some people say there's more to mortal mind. I wonder about that sometimes.

LG: Wanting mortal mind? I've never heard of this.

JW: You haven't? Yeah.

LG: Wanting the Lord would be the immortal?

JW: Yeah. There are some people who believe in that.

LG: It takes a lot of explaining I guess.

JW: Yeah. A woman who was a Christian Scientist and talked to me about that. That there's only one immortal mind, which we tune in to or we don't.

[pause]

LG: No I gave up smoking for three months and then I went back and then I go up and down. I cut them in half, but I'm more sensitive to them than I used to be. I didn't use to. So I have to give it up now, because we're really pushing our luck.

LG: Yeah. You used to smoke Camels and my cigarettes — which, I was a bad influence on you.

JW: Yeah you may be hallucinating on me. We were up in Atlantic City in a restaurant and I got a cigarette out of your blouse or something. And you later on accused me of playing with your boobs.

LG: I regret this. I regret this.

JW: I mean, you wish. Come on now.

LG: You were, so, I did that. I was young and cute and you did it.

JW: This is how black guys get hung. You were hallucinating, come to think of it.

LG: No. It wasn't racial.

JW: It was harassing.

LG: No it wasn't, it was very subtle, and you —

JW: I've spent my life trying to figure out now what I did to make her harass me.

LG: I had my cigarettes in this pocket of a jacket I had and he sticks his hand in and grabs them now what is that?

JW: I didn't. I got the cigarettes.

LG: Well — you knew where they were. You knew exactly where they were. But I shouldn't have put that in print.

JW: You put them there, didn't you?

LG: Yes.

JW: Your cigarettes — and you put them there.

LG: Well next time I won't.

JW: And I had one.

LG: I did not say that. But I put it in print and I regret it now.

JW: Yeah.

LG: I won't put it in print again.

JW: I have this great reputation for chasing anyway.

LG: You didn't chase that much.

[pause]

JW: When I was much younger I would chase. I didn't know what I was doing, going around panting. It looks like the very eyes of God you know, looking at you. And on the back of it says, "A big man is judged by others, not oneself."

MR: I think I have a record with that with him wearing —

JW: Yeah.

MR: I think it's his last record, maybe not.

JW: Yeah, he was doing "Big Man." We did "Big Man" and he died — too soon.

JW: Julian.

LG: Who?

JW: Julian — Cannonball.

LG: Cannonball, yeah.

JW: Well he always used to say, he was doing a live recording from the Village Vanguard and some guy in the audience was making noise and he says, "You know we're making a record now here, live." And the guy says, "Yeah, baby, we're in New York, though, it's New York. We're hip in New York." He says, "Oh, wait a minute." He says, "Don't go like that, you just don't wake up one morning and say to me 'I think I'm going to be hip.'" Oh man, he was —

MR: And hipness is a state of mind — no what is it?

JW: Yeah. It's a fact of life, not a state of mind, baby, being hip. He was one of the most beautiful people. He said the most marvelous things to you.

[pause]

LG: I thought I would ask you of Basie — you still didn't tell me all the people who —

JW: Who influenced me?

LG: Yes. The secret of your success. I mean kids will watch this and they'll say "ah, that's how it's done." Maybe I'll just ask you that. And also, how do you want people to regard you? Basie said he wanted people to call him a nice guy. That's all he wanted.

JW: Well I mean that's a pretty good aspiration, to be just known as a nice fellow you know, someone who is nice. What is this thing about people that will drink or use other stimulants or something like that, and they go off on people you know. Well either you're a nice person or you're not. The drinking isn't going to make you fight somebody or be obstreperous I don't think.

LG: Sometimes drinking brings out your real qualities. I mean some people are real sweet you know and you like them when they're drinking, but they have to learn to be nice without it I guess eventually.

JW: Some people become more ebullient you know. Jolly. Really drink helps them to relax and become more themselves.

LG: When I was a kid I used to drink to loosen up. As a tranquilizer it was wonderful for me. Then I had to give it up.

JW: What, drinking?

LG: Yeah. In my early twenties I stopped drinking.

JW: Couldn't handle it, huh?

LG: No, not at all.

JW: Um hum. That's good if you know you can't handle it.

JW: Why would you have that much?

LG: Why did I have — are we on film? —

JW: Yeah, of course we are.

LG: Well why did I drink that much? I don't know. It was just, I used to hang out with drinking people really, and —

JW: I still do.

LG: I went into the clubs, you know like where there was a lot of drinking and smoking going on, and I enjoyed it. And I thought I could hold it. And I didn't get drunk, so I could have a bunch of drinks, like six, seven drinks in a night of scotch. And being young I got away with it. But then in my early twenties I started to feel sick. So I said well I'd better cut out the drinking until I feel better. I didn't know it was the drinking that was making me sick.

JW: Oh, see—

LG: And so I was not acting right. I was nervous from it and a lot of things. So I just stopped drinking. And I never went back to it. I'd have a glass of wine or two.

JW: That's good.

LG: But I was drinking every night. I was out with drinking people about five nights a week.

JW: We do, we have a drink before dinner every night.

LG: That's good for you. Wine is good.

JW: But that's it. And we rarely have wine with meals at home.

LG: Well that's good for you though.

JW: We have milk all the time. We have two percent now you know, milk.

LG: Oh that's living dangerously. I use one percent.

JW: Oh yeah? But we don't really drink per se, period. If we go out somewhere we'll have a drink before dinner, and wine with, and maybe finish with a Cognac.

LG: Well you noticed when you were young and on the road that the people that abused liquor and stuff, they died young. And you remember, I remember you told me that you decided to play golf to save your life really.

JW: It might have. Because —

LG: You instinctively made good choices.

JW: Well I like sports and golf is such a challenge. And as a guy said, "Golf is a search for infinity itself."

LG: Yeah?

JW: Yeah, golly. You know each day it's different. The guy says, "Oh I shot a 63 today, and if I hadn't missed those two putts, it would have been a 61." It's always, and like that's phenomenal for goodness sake.

LG: Yeah, that's a good score.

JW: Yeah. But it's a wonderful, wonderful game. And the thing that really got to me about it was you don't have to have anybody else to play with.

LG: Yeah. You could just walk around by yourself.

JW: That's right.

LG: A little lonesome maybe.

JW: You can contemplate and consider and make adjustments and what have you to see how, as Sam Snead said once when he was on the practice range, somebody said, "Oh you're trying to get it together, Sam?" He said, "No, if you're trying to get it together you have no business out here. I just want to see how I'm hitting it today."

LG: Yeah. Every day is new.

JW: There you go.

LG: Every day is a challenge. Even now that you're going to be doing this concert, and you've been playing concerts more years than — a lot of years. Do you still feel it's a challenge to go on?

JW: Oh, Lord yes. I'm doing three things written by Benny Carter that I've never performed. And one is a duet with Dianne Reeves. And she is like, oh, talk about holding someone in awe, and admiring somebody greatly. That lady, she's such a musician and such a voice, such a presence, such beauty and warmth and it's really —

LG: Yes she's a stunning artist.

JW: God, you know I sang with Carmen, with Sarah and Ella—

LG: Right, yes. Did you sing with Ella on recordings?

JW: Oh yeah. Ella first.

LG: Oh I knew Carmen and Sarah.

JW: Ella first, yeah. "Party Blues" with Ella, and "Too Close for Comfort." Stuff we did for the 1957 Metronome All-Stars. And Shirley Horn.

LG: Shirley Horn too?

JW: Yeah. Shirley Horn, did a thing with her.

LG: Do you feel that you are a role model in the way that some people might have been role models for you? I mean I know a singer who just idolizes you — oh I can't think of it — Kevin Mahagony. He wants to do all the songs you've done. He wants to be you.

JW: There's a marvelous performer, piano player and singer named Paul Broadnax. He's coming to town just to have a picture made. He has just put out an album and he did almost everything I did in his CD. He and Donn Trenner put it together. And I love it when these kids do things that I do. They honored me at — what was it — at the Hollywood Bowl and all the singers were doing things that I did. And my piano player, Norman Simmons came to me and says, "They're not going to leave anything for you to

LG: What do you feel is the secret of your success? Would you like to just reflect on that for a minute? Is there any secret? I know you said exposure was very important.

JW: The television I think is a big factor I think. I probably had more television exposure, national television exposure, than any other artist quote unquote they would say is a jazz performer.

LG: Yes. Johnny Carson was a —

JW: Johnny Carson, but also there was Merv Griffin. I did a lot of Merv Griffin. Merv, when he was here at the little theater at Times Square you know, and early, starting in 1961 I did Mike Douglas regularly, at least every month I would be on Mike Douglas' show.

LG: That's very important.

JW: Yeah. And I did Art Linkletter, every time I went to the coast. I did Steve Allen when he was here in New York doing the Tonight Show before Johnny Carson and before Jack Parr. I did, and then when he went to the west coast I did his show out there, Steve Allen's show out there as well. And Don O'Connor had a show out there, I did his show there, and I also did his show when he was being considered for the Tonight Show here in New York City. And I did local television shows, every city we went to. And I did television in Chicago, Illinois in 1950 I think it was, the fellow named Al Benson, every Saturday night he'd have an hour show. And we did his show every week. And I did Gary Moore's television show a couple of times here out of New York. I did Perry Como's show here in New York. I did Dinah Shore's show several times. And I don't know who I'm leaving out but I mean I did a lot of television. A lot of T.V. You know who else did a lot of T.V?" Bill Basie.

LG: Oh, yes.

JW: With Big Sid. Remember that?

LG: I don't remember, but you told me. You said there was nothing better for his career than that. That was before you were working with him.

JW: Oh and Billy Taylor too, I did wonderful things for Billy Taylor in a big band from Kennedy Center. And radio. There was a lot of radio things we did too. I did things with the Airmen of Note, recordings. I did work with the Navy Commodores too. And it —

LG: So you made yourself accessible.

JW: Yeah, I think.

LG: You loved to make yourself accessible to people.

JW: I did a tour of the camps in Germany one year. Ellis Larkin and I went over and did a tour over there of different bases in Germany. And of course I did those bases with Basie's orchestra as well. But Armed Forces Radio, Bobby Troup used to have a show out on the west coast. And I remember sitting with him with stacks, you know with my records,

RCA Victor I think at the time, and he was doing that. And Willis Conover, forever I did Willis Conover.

LG: The Voice of America?

JW: The Voice of America. And I realized what that really meant when I went with Clark Terry for the State Department. We started the African tour in Sierra Leone. And we were rehearsing prior to the concert that afternoon, and a guy came in in a gray suit, a black guy, and he was saying [sings] "Nobody me — Joe Williams! Joe Williams!" And I thought, I said yeah, there it is, Voice of America, man, Armed Forces Radio. That you were known in second, third world countries all over the world, because of radio and television. I remember sitting in Turkey in Ankara, Turkey after having stood in the receiving line for the Counsel General and greeted the different people from different countries, everybody coming to the house, to the Counsel General's home. I got a drink and I had a nice scotch and soda, and I walked into a little room and sat by myself. And suddenly the television set came on and there was Duke Ellington and the orchestra broadcasting from Monterey, at the Monterey Festival, with Woody Herman and I saw Paul Gonsalves in the background.

LG: Exciting to see that stuff.

JW: And the frozen frame at the end was a picture of Ellington, Woody Herman and I with our arms around each other, and we are laughing you know. But here I was in Ankara, Turkey looking at this. And so the Counsel General came in and sat down with me and had a drink. And I was discussing it with him and he said that Duke was in, Edward was in Turkey when Jack Kennedy was shot and killed. He was doing a tour for the State Department. And he canceled the tour and came back home after that. But I thought about the parable in the Bible. "I go to prepare a place for you that wherever I go you may be also." And then, Jack Kennedy's words, "God's work is our own." You know it all came together. I thought about Buck Clayton and Benny Carter and Duke Ellington and Dizzy Gillespie, and all the people who've been to the Middle East before I went there, and conducted themselves in such a manner that when Clark Terry and I came, we were greeted with open arms and were given celebrity because of the fact that so many elegant and wonderful and gentle and genuine people had been there before us.

LG: The best ambassadors for our country.

JW: Oh, man, really.

LG: How would you like people to regard you?

JW: Me?

LG: Yeah. Basie said he wanted people to think of him and call him a nice guy.

JW: Yeah, I said that's pretty good. That's pretty good to aspire to that. Say hey, Joe

LG: He is.

JW: He's a nice fellow. Yeah he's a nice man.

LG: I'll say that.

JW: Oh thank you.

LG: I've been saying that for years.

JW: Oh thank you.

LG: Well it's been wonderful to see you again.

JW: Always, Leslie.

LG: And you look wonderful.

JW: Thank you, you too.

LG: Oh thank you.

JW: You look good. Yeah.

LG: Thanks. Okay?